

and time-consuming task to troubleshoot them without a proper network monitoring tool. Let me share two real-life experiences where Ntop was used to troubleshoot Internet speed problems.

A problem was reported that Internet connectivity used to slow down at 1 p.m. every day and would return to its normal speed automatically after some random time. Ntop was set up to monitor traffic from 12 p.m. onwards. It was evident from the reports that Microsoft Windows updates were scheduled at 1 p.m. daily, and all the PCs on the network were trying to connect to the Windows updates site at the same time, causing the Internet connection to get bogged down.

Another problem was that the ERP server and the Internet connection would slow down at 4 p.m. every day, and would return to normal speed after about two hours. Ntop monitoring results made it clear that a large number of remote users logged into the ERP server via VPN at 4 p.m., to start day-closing operations. These operations included using the server to generate reports/invoices, and printing them to their remote terminals. Multiple simultaneous user log-ins slowed down the ERP server, and the number of reports being printed on remote printers via the VPN slowed down Internet connectivity. Both, Internet connectivity and the ERP server were upgraded to solve the issue.

Ntop can be effectively used in other situations:

- Detecting Trojan horses by watching for traffic on ports used by these malware.
- Detecting MAC cloning/spoofing on the network.
- Port scans targeting a particular IP.
- Identifying unwanted protocols in use on the network.

To ensure effective and efficient utilisation of network resources, it's an excellent idea for a company to design a network security policy that requires:

- Continuous monitoring of the company network.
- Analysis of the generated data, for anomalies.
- Fixing of identified problems immediately.

Ntop is definitely a handy, simple-to-use and free tool to fulfil such policy requirements! At the time of writing this article, Ntop ranks first among all network traffic monitoring tools, 8th among all packet sniffers, and 36th among all network security tools, as surveyed by www.sectools.org. 

References

Ntop home page: www.ntop.org
List of top 100 network security tools: www.sectools.org

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